



IN STARTING AND WAGING A WAR, IT IS NOT RIGHT THAT MATTERS BUT VICTORY

NAZI INVASION OF POLAND (1939–1945)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

World War II

BEFORE

1919 The Treaty of Versailles at the end of World War I humiliates Germany and sows the seeds for future conflict.

1922 The Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR) is founded.

1933 The Enabling Act gives Adolf Hitler dictatorial power in Germany.

AFTER

1942–1943 The Soviets defeat the Germans at Stalingrad.

1944 The June 6 D-Day Landings, which were the largest amphibious military operation in history, begin the liberation of Western Europe.

1945 As Russian troops win the Battle of Berlin, Hitler commits suicide. The Germans surrender unconditionally.

In August 1939, Nazi Germany and the Soviet Union signed a nonaggression pact, also secretly agreeing to invade and then divide Poland between them. Russian leader Joseph Stalin had decided that in the event of war, Germany offered the best hope of Soviet security. One week later, on September 1, 1939, more than a million German troops invaded Poland

from the west. Soon after, on September 17, Russian troops attacked Poland from the east. The context for this unprovoked assault, as declared by the German *Führer*, Adolf Hitler, was the pursuit of *Lebensraum*, “living space” deemed necessary for the expansion of the German people, whom Hitler saw as a superior “Aryan master race,” with the right to displace inferior races.

The invasion lasted just over a month. Trapped between two huge, well-armed powers, the Polish air force and army fought valiantly, but they lacked modern aircraft and tanks. The German Luftwaffe was quickly able to gain command of the skies. In the end, Poland’s aviators and soldiers, fighting on two fronts, were overwhelmed.

The invasion ended in a resounding victory, and it added to Hitler’s increasing belief that he was a military genius. Some areas in western Poland were absorbed into Germany, while territory east of the Bug River was annexed by the Soviet Union.

The Nazi regime in Poland

The Nazis imposed a brutal regime on the German part of Poland. Hitler was bent on the elimination of anyone who stood in the way of German domination.

As part of Hitler’s plan for ethnic cleansing, around 5 million Polish Jews were rounded up and herded into ghettos. The invasion of Poland gave some forewarning of the violence that would soon be visited upon scores of countries and countless people around the globe.